Lesson 35 material: Evidence and Claims: A Model Essay and When to Cite

4.1: Introduction

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Original page, with audio and online exercises:
https://human.libretexts.org/Bookshelves/Languages/English_as_a_Second_Language/Reading_Writing_Research_and_Reasoning%3A_An_Advanced_ESL_Text/04%3A_In
Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

What will we learn in this chapter?

In this chapter, you will learn how to use evidence from other sources to support an argument. You will learn about different types of evidence and how to choose the most effective for your topic. In addition, you will learn how to effectively quote, summarize, or paraphrase the outside information and connect it to your own ideas. Lastly, you will learn how to cite the information that you are using to support your argument and avoid plagiarism.

Why is this important?

Most academic writing is based on using other texts (books, articles, films, etc.) to support a point; in other words, you need to use other people's writing as proof or evidence of your own argument. To make your own argument more persuasive, you need to be able to choose the best evidence from your sources and smoothly connect it to your own ideas. However, it is also important to show where your information comes from. This will make your own writing more persuasive by showing where you got your information and allowing your readers to check it themselves; even more importantly, it shows your "academic honesty" and that you are not trying to claim that something is your own idea when you learned it from another source.

What theme will this chapter focus on?

What does your native language mean to you? In this chapter, we will look at native languages and the importance of maintaining them. Sometimes when immigrants arrive in the United States, they feel pressure to stop using their home language in order to assimilate into their new home. People who arrive as children may not yet have very much formal education in their first language, and in the rush to learn English, they miss out on the opportunity to become fluently bilingual. But maintaining home languages is important for academic, cultural, social, and emotional reasons. School systems and state and local governments have long argued about the best way to educate multilingual students. The readings in this chapter explore this theme.

(Picture: A person speaks at a school board meeting)

Figure: Standing up for Bilingual and Public Education by Milwaukee Teachers' Education Association is licensed under CC-BY-NC 2.0

Learning objectives

In this chapter, you will learn to

- evaluate and select appropriate text evidence to support your points.
- integrate quotations and paraphrases using MLA citation style.
- introduce and analyze evidence to connect it to your own ideas.
- compose essays that avoid plagiarism.
- format papers in MLA style.

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4.2: Sample Student Research Essay- Heritage Languages

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https://human.libretexts.org/Bookshelves/Languages/English_as_a_Second_Language/Reading_Writing_Research_and_Reasoning%3A_An_Advanced_ESL_Text/04%3A_In_Heritage_Languages
Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Reading: Student essay on heritage languages

The link below opens a version of the sample essay formatted in MLA 8th edition:

Sample Student Research Paper Heritage Languages.pdf

Joana Coelho Silverio

Professor X

Advanced ESL Composition

27 April 2021

Heritage Languages: the Language of Emotions

“Heritage language is the essence of who we are," writes Clara Lee Brown, describing the feelings of Korean immigrant parents she interviewed about their children's language (33). I come from a family of immigrants. For this reason, I know the importance of maintaining the home language, in particular, to have the feeling of belonging to somewhere. Today, people move all around the world and could live in many different countries. Therefore, immigrants feel the need to transmit their language and culture to their children as part of their identity. Nevertheless, some people think that the new country’s language is more important, and don’t want to transmit the heritage language to their children. Although there is a loss of heritage language by the second-generation immigrants, families should keep trying to maintain their mother tongue because our language is our identity.

One significant action for maintaining a child's heritage language is to speak it at home. According to Martin Guardado, an assistant professor in the English Language Program at Alberta University, using the heritage language to communicate at home is an important way to preserve the values, convictions, culture, and identity of the family. The transmission of a language happens when the language is spoken and nothing is better than parents speaking their home language with their children because it will be an emotional language. Also, when parents talk to their children in their home language, they transmit their culture with stories and the family background. In fact, that helps families to keep their identity and their cohesion. As the father of a bilingual child named Nina explains, “We need to talk about our roots as immigrants. Keeping Korean means keeping our roots” (qtd. in Brown 33). As this quote shows, immigrant parents believe that without communication with children in their heritage language, they may become a disconnected family with no relationship (Brown 33). In other words, the heritage language is connected to the culture and the identity of the family. The parents can also try to transmit their culture in the new language, but it is unlikely that they will succeed, because language is closely linked to emotions, and people are better at explaining feelings in their home language. An interesting example of this is that in Portuguese, we have the word ‘saudade.' That word in English means a combination of words like ‘missing,' ‘nostalgia’ and ‘homesickness.’ There is no direct translation in English to that Portuguese word. So, we need to know and understand the Portuguese language and culture to have this feeling. This demonstrates how important is the transmission of the culture through the home language. Communicating in the heritage language at home is an important way to develop and maintain language and culture.

Bilingual and heritage language schools also play an important role in maintaining immigrant children's bilingual proficiency. Languages need to be spoken, but sometimes, just talking in the heritage language at home is not enough, and schools can help to develop literacy skills. According to Ruth Lingxin Yan, a professor at Nebraska College of Education and Human Sciences, "parents who held the view that heritage language learning was connected to the academic performance of their children in regular English-language school tended to choose as the ideal school bilingual schools or English-language schools with extra instruction using the heritage language” (105). In other words, parents understand that learning two or more languages helps children in their academic performance. Some studies show that bilingualism has personal, intellectual, and societal advantages (Kang, 432). An interesting example of this is the variety of opinions that can exist in a group, due to cultural diversity. Different people have different viewpoints, and that is a social wealth. Besides, today, it is so important to know more than a language, that it is in the interest of second-generation immigrants to learn their home language while it is easier for them, because they can speak with their families. Schools that can help families to keep their mother tongue are appreciated.

An additional important way to preserve the heritage language is being around native speakers. Having relatives and compatriots that can talk with immigrant children in their mother tongue contributes to developing and maintaining the home language and culture. Stevens and Ishizawa explain, "Specifically, the presence of siblings and grandparents in the household increases the opportunity for Spanish use because older siblings tend to be more proficient in the mother tongue and grandparents' lack of English proficiency creates the necessity for communication in Spanish” (qtd. in Tran 263). Also, Guardado states that it is usual that families rely on these relatives to improve the home language and culture. In fact, we are more successful in learning a language when we are immersed in a community that speaks this same language. For example, for my cousins that were born in Switzerland, it was easy to learn Portuguese, because they have relatives that live near them, and the Portuguese community in Switzerland is big. Therefore, they could always speak Portuguese while they were learning the language. In contrast, my niece, who lives in the United States, does not have relatives besides me who speak Portuguese. Consequently, she understands almost everything, but she does not speak Portuguese. In cases like these, the possibility to go some months on vacation to the home country, being with family, could help children to learn the language. As one of Hyun-Sook Kang's interviewees recalls, “We . . . spen[t] a whole summer in Korea last year. Henry was five years old. . . . We just sent him to a local kindergarten there, so that he could meet and make friends with Korean kids around his age. His Korean…improved a lot during that time period” (qtd. in Kang 435). Sending the immigrants' children to their home country on holidays is one way that parents have found to put their children in full immersion of the home language. Not to mention that besides language, they will learn the customs, the culture, and even their family background. My niece will go to a Portuguese kindergarten this summer in Portugal, and I hope that she improves her fluency in the language, particularly in order to be able to talk to her great-grandmothers.

On the other hand, some immigrants' children do not learn their heritage language. Clara Lee Brown, an associate professor of the College of Education, Health and Human Sciences, at the University of Tennessee, explains that some parents believe that it is more important to learn the new language from the country where they live. So, they speak that language at home in the hope that children will learn this new language faster (31). However, it is important to also consider the fact that "second-generation children who are fluently bilingual performed better on academic tests and had better GPAs compared to monolinguals…" (San Diego et al. qtd. in Tran 261). Additionally, many children, refuse to speak their heritage language when they grew up, and frequently just the oldest child speaks the native language whereas the siblings start to speak the new language with each other and they do not get to learn the home language. Nevertheless, it lies with parents to motivate children to learn the heritage language making them feel proud of their culture.

In conclusion, families have a major role in maintaining and developing their children's heritage language. Families, with distinct languages in the various countries, have different reasons to keep or not the home language through generations. Despite this, communication between household members is necessary; for this reason, it is important to speak the heritage language at home in an attempt to preserve the family identity and to transmit the culture to the second generation. Moreover, bilingual and heritage language schools could help parents to teach the heritage language to kids. Finally, immersion in the heritage language can increase the motivation that second-generation immigrants need to maintain their native language. It is important to understand that knowing more than a language is having a world of possibilities.

Works Cited

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Kang, Hyun-Sook. "Korean-Immigrant Parents' Support of Their American-Born Children's Development and Maintenance of the Home Language." *Early Childhood Education Journal*, vol. 41, no. 6, Nov. 2013, pp. 431-438. EBSCO *host*.

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"Heritage Languages: the Language of Emotions," a research paper by Joana Coelho Silverio. License: CC BY.

Attached: Sample Student Research Paper Heritage Languages

A long document (1,497 words), not printed here. Open it from the original page above or from your computer's attachments folder (file: Sample_Student_Research_Paper_Heritage_Languages.pdf). Your tutor has its full text.

4.3: Using Evidence to Support Claims

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Supporting claims with evidence

In any essay or research paper that you write, you will make claims about your topic, and support your claims with evidence. This evidence shows the reader why you came to the conclusions that you are presenting.

The types of support you develop and include in an essay will depend on what you are writing and why you are writing. For example, if you are writing a reflective or response essay, you will use more of your own personal experiences, observations, and examples. On the other hand, if you are writing a research paper, you will rely on quotations, reasons, and facts. If you do use personal experience or observations, those should be additional support for points that are already supported by your research.

Types of evidence

Here are examples of the main types of evidence or support used in academic writing:

- **General Facts** (with a citation if this was learned through research): Some parents believe that it is more important to learn the new language of the new country where they live (Brown 31).
- **Statistics** (facts that rely on numbers) (with a citation): More than ten percent of children in the US public school system are not native speakers of English (Mata-McMahon).
- **Quotations or paraphrases from experts** (with a citation): Catherine Snow, Professor of Education at Harvard University, insists that "[i]t's ironic that we have students walking up staircases at one end of their school building to attend Spanish foreign language classes while at the other end of the same building native Spanish speakers are being taught English and content in ways that lead to their loss of Spanish."
- **Examples** (with a citation if this was learned through research): As a Korean immigrant father named Mr. Rhee explains, his family "spen[t] a whole summer in Korea last year. Henry was 5 years old. . . . We just sent him to a local kindergarten there, so that he could meet and make friends with Korean kids around his age. His Korean was improved a lot during that time period" (qtd. in Kang 435).
- **Personal Experience or Observations**: It was easy for my cousins who were born in Switzerland to learn Portuguese because there is a large Portuguese community there. In contrast, my niece is growing up in the United States and I am her only Portuguese-speaking relative. Consequently, she understands almost everything, but she cannot speak Portuguese.

Recognizing evidence

Let's look at a paragraph from a paper on heritage languages and see what evidence the writer uses:

Notice this!

What types of evidence do you see in this example paragraph?

On the other hand, unfortunately, some immigrant do not prioritize teaching their children their home language. Clara Lee Brown, an associate professor of the College of Education, Health and Human Sciences, at the University of Tennessee, claims that some parents believe that it is more important to learn the new language of the new country where they live. So, they speak that language at home in the hope that children will learn this new language faster (Brown 31). However, it is important to also consider the fact that "second-generation children who are fluently bilingual performed better on academic tests and had better GPAs compared to monolinguals…" (San Diego, Rumbaut & Cornelius qtd. in Tran 261). Additionally, many children refuse to speak their heritage language when they grew up, and frequently just the oldest child speaks the native language whereas younger siblings start to communicate with each other in the new language and do not master home language. Thus, parents should motivate children to learn their heritage language making them feel proud of their culture.

Using different types of evidence

Let's try adding evidence from an article about bilingual education, such as in the classroom in figure 4.3.1, to a body paragraph.

(Picture: a smiling teacher with two young smiling students in an elementary classroom)

Figure: "Bilingual Classroom Tour and Presentation" by One America is licensed under CC-BY-NC-SA

Try this!

1. Read this short article and look for different kinds of evidence to support this topic sentence: "Public schools should help immigrant children to maintain their heritage language."
2. Choose one fact that can be used to support the topic sentence. Paraphrase it and write it down with a correct citation.
3. Choose one quotation from an expert or statistic that can be used to support the topic sentence. Write it down with a correct citation.
4. Think about if you have any personal experiences or observations related to this topic, or if you know of an example. If you do, write it down.
5. Write a concluding explanation of how this evidence supports the topic sentence.
6. Check the sample body paragraph. How similar or different is it to your paragraph?

Reading from an online magazine: 1 in 10 US students are English learners

Jennifer Mata-McMahon, *University of Maryland, Baltimore County*

More than 1 in 10 of the nation's approximately 50 million public school students speak a native language other than English, according to the latest federal data. Roughly 3 in 4 of these English learners speak Spanish.

The percentage of U.S. students who are learning how to speak English has grown significantly in recent years, rising from 8% in fall of 2000 to 10% by 2017, the data indicate.

The prevalence of these students varies greatly across the country, ranging from 0.8% in West Virginia to 19.2% in California. The share of English learners is highest among young children, hovering around 16% between kindergarten and second grade. Typically, younger children have less exposure than older students to English because they are primarily communicating with relatives in their native languages. By the time students are nearing high school graduation, the percentage of English learners drops to 4.6%.

Students who remain fluent in their native language while learning to speak English become bilingual, which has many advantages. Bilingual people tend to be better at connecting with others from different ethnic backgrounds and cultures. They are also better at solving problems.

Once they grow up, bilingual adults often have better job opportunities and may earn higher salaries than those who no longer speak their native language. Also, research indicates that being bilingual can increase creativity and heighten cognitive ability.

Researchers have found that attending dual-language programs, where instructional time is split between English and another language (oftentimes Spanish), attended by both native and non-native English speakers, help children become bilingual. But only 35 states offered these programs, according to the Department of Education's latest data.

Without those opportunities, English learners tend to stop being fluent in their first language when they reach high school and miss out on all the benefits of becoming bilingual students.

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(To see a sample body paragraph, check 4.12: Integrating Evidence Answer Key)

Works Cited

Brown, Clara Lee. "Maintaining Heritage Language: Perspectives of Korean Parents." *Multicultural Education*, vol. 19, no. 1, Fall 2011, pp. 31-37. Eric.ed.gov.

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Body paragraph on heritage languages and examples of fact, example, and personal experience are from "Heritage Languages: the Language of Emotions", a research paper by Joana Coelho Silverio. License: CC BY.

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"Supporting Claims with Evidence" and some of the types of evidence are adapted from 6.2 "Types of Support" in the text *Writing, Reading, and College Success: A First-Year Composition Course for All Learners*. License: CC BY NC SA.

"1 in 10 US Students are English Learners" is reprinted from *The Conversation*. License: CC BY ND.

Links on the original page

- original article: https://theconversation.com/1-in-10-us-students-are-english-learners-143324
- "The True Failure of Foreign Language Instruction.": https://theconversation.com/the-true-failure-of-foreign-language-instruction-80352

4.4: Knowing When to Cite

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What is citation?

As an academic writer, you are expected to not just use your own ideas in writing but to also back up your ideas with information from other books, articles, videos, etc. like the multilingual library resources shown in Figure 4.4.1. In addition, you need to show your readers where you got your information from. This process is called *citation* or *citing your sources*. Citation makes you a more credible writer because it shows that you have spent time reading and thinking about other sources and that you have evidence to support your points. Equally importantly, it helps you to avoid plagiarism.

(Picture: Library informational materials in a variety of languages including Spanish, Chinese, Arabic, Indonesian, and German.)

Figure: "Multilingual Welcome" by Valley Library (Oregon State University) is licensed under CC BY-NC-SA 2.0.

Citation has two parts: an in-text citation is a reference to the source author's name (or the source title if there is no author) in the sentence with information from that source, and the Works Cited page, which is a more detailed list of references at the end of your paper. You will learn more about these in Formatting Your Paper.

Finding citations

We will Let's look at a body paragraph that a student wrote on preserving native languages.

Notice this!

What sentences in this sample paragraph include citations? Why did the writer cite those sentences?

The most important thing immigrant parents can do is to speak heritage language at home. Using the heritage language to communicate at home is an important way to preserve the values, convictions, culture and identity of the family (Guardado). The transmission of a language happens when the language is spoken and nothing better than parents speaking their home language with their children because it will be an emotional language. Also, when parents talk to their children in their home language, they transmit their culture with stories and family background. In fact, that help families to keep their identity and their cohesion. As an immigrant father explains, “We need to talk about our roots as immigrants. Keeping Korean means keeping our roots ” (qtd. in Brown 33). As this quote shows, immigrant parents believe that without the communication with children in their heritage language, they would probably become disconnected from their past and family identity. While parents may also transmit their culture in their new language, they may be less successful because the home language is so closely tied to emotions.

When to cite (or not to cite)

Some writers are not sure what ideas need to be cited or not. You **must** cite:

- Any time that you use exact words from a source. These words must be in quotation marks.
- Any time you paraphrase a source.
- Any time that you use information or ideas that came from another source, which you did not know before doing your research, you must cite the source of the information.

Be particularly careful any time you use numbers or statistics from a source. Without a citation, it will look as if you just made this information up!

However, you do not need to cite:

- Information that is general knowledge—things that everybody knows.
- Statements that are obviously true.
- Anecdotal evidence from your own experience.

Deciding if you should cite

Let's look at some sample sentences from a research paper on preserving native languages:

Try this!

Should these sentences be cited? After you decide, check the answers.

1. More than half of the 6,900 languages in the world will disappear over the next 100 years.
2. It was easy for my cousins who were born in Switzerland to learn Portuguese because there is a large Portuguese community there. In contrast, my niece is growing up in the United States and I am her only Portuguese speaking relative. Consequently, she understands almost everything, but she cannot speak Portuguese.
3. Most immigrants feel the need to transmit their language and culture to their children because it is part of their identity.
4. Children of immigrants who are bilingual have better academic performance than children of immigrants who do not know their parents' native language.

(To see answers, check 4.12: Integrating Evidence Answer Key)

Works Cited

Brown, Clara Lee. “Maintaining Heritage Language: Perspectives of Korean Parents.” *Multicultural Education*, vol. 19, no. 1, Fall 2011, pp. 31-37. Eric.ed.gov.

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Links on the original page

- "Why Do Languages Die?": http://www.britannica.com/story/why-do-languages-die